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Six months among the Ahaggar Tuareg

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In a joking way, to be a real wit, the man could answer: "If I should find myself in this situation, I would first gather the flock, I would re-tether the ass, I would put the pot back on the fire, and only then would I pay attention to the woman," and there would be a chorus of indignant protests.

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The woman makes it a point of honor to have as many admirers as possible. This is a proof that she is pretty and will not have trouble in getting married.

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The ahal, begun after sunset, lasts quite late into the night, and the pale light that is shed by the stars allows shamelessness to have free rein. Although the married women joke and take part in the games, they behave themselves comparatively well. The others, however, may sit on the knees of their admirers. They kiss, but in a special way. Since the man must never uncover his mouth, he lowers his veil under his nose, and he piously smells the nose! of his loved one, who herself may kiss him. Even intimate handling (proh pudor! /oh, shame/) is allowed, which is never seen among the Arabs.

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During these gatherings, when the amz'ad is played, it is listened to with great pleasure. This instrument has a way of exciting 10 the Tuareg, who utter "Ouh! ouh!" as a sign of pleasure. They have even made a verb of it: isouhouh.

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But now is the time when the camels come from the pasture. They must be milked: that is the az'ouz'edj □ (from ez'edj □, to milk). The women get up, and those present are given milk to drink. They will have to disperse.

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